carpet weaving, wood carving or leather work, artisans working in these old industries are being encouraged to get on board online platforms in order to gain exposure to a wider market. Common Facility Centres (CFCs), which provide workers with a range of help, are to be set up in all districts.

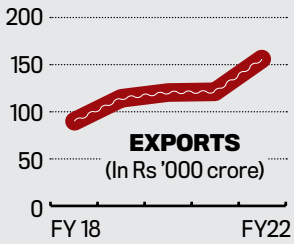
Sunil Kumar, joint commissioner, ODOP, explains: "The government provides a 25 per cent subsidy on loans distributed under this scheme and trains artisans. CFCs are playing an important role in the development of these products. A CFC has all the facilities required for grading, packing and storing ODOP products under one roof. We have five centres, 28 more are sanctioned. Ernst & Young are project consultants of the scheme and have conducted studies of all districts/ products. They suggest innovations to artisans so that their products gain traction on international platforms."

The state government signed an MoU with e-commerce website Flipkart in 2020 to sell ODOP products on the website, having earlier tied up with Amazon. ODOP officials say that products worth Rs 1,600 crore have been sold through Flipkart in the past two years. ODOP also has its own online platform to sell products. The UP Handicrafts Development and Marketing Corporation has launched an e-marketplace,www.odopmart.com, to sell them. ODOP has tied up with the Quality Council of India to standardise quality as well as with the National Institute of Fashion Technology to improve design. For Yogi Adityanath, "ODOP is a symbol of UP's heritage." The chief minister makes it a point to give gift hampers of ODOP products to special guests as far as possible.

Ashfaq Ali, a resident of Sitapur, who works as an artisan at a CFC, talks of how he was earlier in Panipat, making cotton dhurries. But after getting a job here, he is staying put. His colleague Karimullah, who spent eight years in Panipat, says, "I came to Sitapur during the lockdown. After a few weeks, I got the same sort of employment here."

RISING POWER

Increase in UP's exports in the past five years*

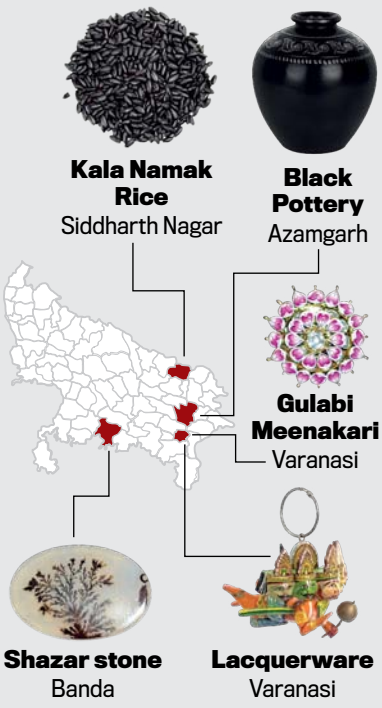


HOW ODOP HELPS

- Provides financial aid to artisans
- Trains them about the possible innovations related to their crafts
- Sells them on various online platforms
- Common Facility Centre for raw materials, testing, design development and exhibitions

BACK FROM THE BRINK

Products that were near extinction before the ODOP scheme revived them



Graphic by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY

Source: *Uttar Pradesh government figures

THE ODOP SCHEME IS A SUCCESS, BUT SOME DISTRICTS NEED A LEG-UP. THE UP LEATHER INDUSTRY'S PROBLEMS MUST BE FIXED TOO

Hayat Kausar, secretary of CFC Sitapur, claims that such centres are helping artisans to stay on. "Sitapur is famous for dhurries. For making dhurries, we now have advanced machines like the twister for doubling the threads, Jacquard for designing and tufting for the final design," he says.

Though the ODOP scheme has taken off splendidly, it's not an unqualified success, since some districts still need a leg-up. Then there is UP's all-important leather industry. Though export of leather goods is projected as an important part of ODOP, the industry based in and around Kanpur is facing multiple challenges. These range from a paucity of skilled labour to lack of design capabilities and the unavailability of quality and cheap accessories. Sehgal says, "We are solving the issues of tannery owners and connecting them more with ODOP buyers. As leather is in huge demand, they can make up for the losses during the pandemic." Sehgal also mentions the newly launched OSOP (one station one product) plan on the lines of ODOP. Under this, railway stations across UP will serve as promotional hubs, showcasing the state's ODOP scheme. As part of this initiative, ODOP products of respective districts will be displayed at the most-visited platform of all railway stations in that particular district. For example, if a train is passing through Ayodhya district, all its railway stations will display the ODOP products of Ayodhya. In this way, those districts that still need help in the promotion of their products will be covered, adds Sehgal. The exquisite craftsmanship on display in ODOP products deserve every support. ■